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Post-Assad Syria: Could the country become a second Afghanistan?

With the overthrow of Bashar al-Assad, Syria has entered a new phase in its history. The 50-year regime has collapsed, and everyone is now waiting for the start of a political process that reflects the will of the people. Now the main issue is who will be the future leader of Syria, who will come to power. In this process, the leader of Hayat Tahrir al-Sham (HTS), Abu Muhammad al-Jolani, has come to the fore. He is known as the person who claims to shape the future political architecture of Syria. He is already in the spotlight both in Syria's domestic politics and in international relations with his statements. Many are wary of his authoritarian approach and ruthless attitude towards his opponents. His past ties with al-Qaeda, as well as close cooperation with Turkey and Qatar, do not go unnoticed.

In addition to all this, the HTS group currently largely controls the processes in Syria. A temporary transitional government has also been established and new elections have been

announced. Interestingly, Jolani, who is not represented in the temporary government, has announced that he will participate in the elections. That is, he wants to become president.

Many believe that Syria could become a second Afghanistan. Jolani, however, said that Syria will not be like Afghanistan. He believes that the two countries are "very different."

We present an article on the topic from the "**Kaspi**" newspaper.



HTS wants to be removed from the blacklist

The views of UN Special Envoy Geir Pedersen, who met with Jolani some time ago, on whether the HTS leader will be accepted by the world are also noteworthy. According to him, it is vital that the new Syrian leadership respects the rights of all the different religious and ethnic groups in the country. According to Pedersen, Jolani "said very positive things" in his meeting with him. However, he stressed that the decision to remove HTS from the list of

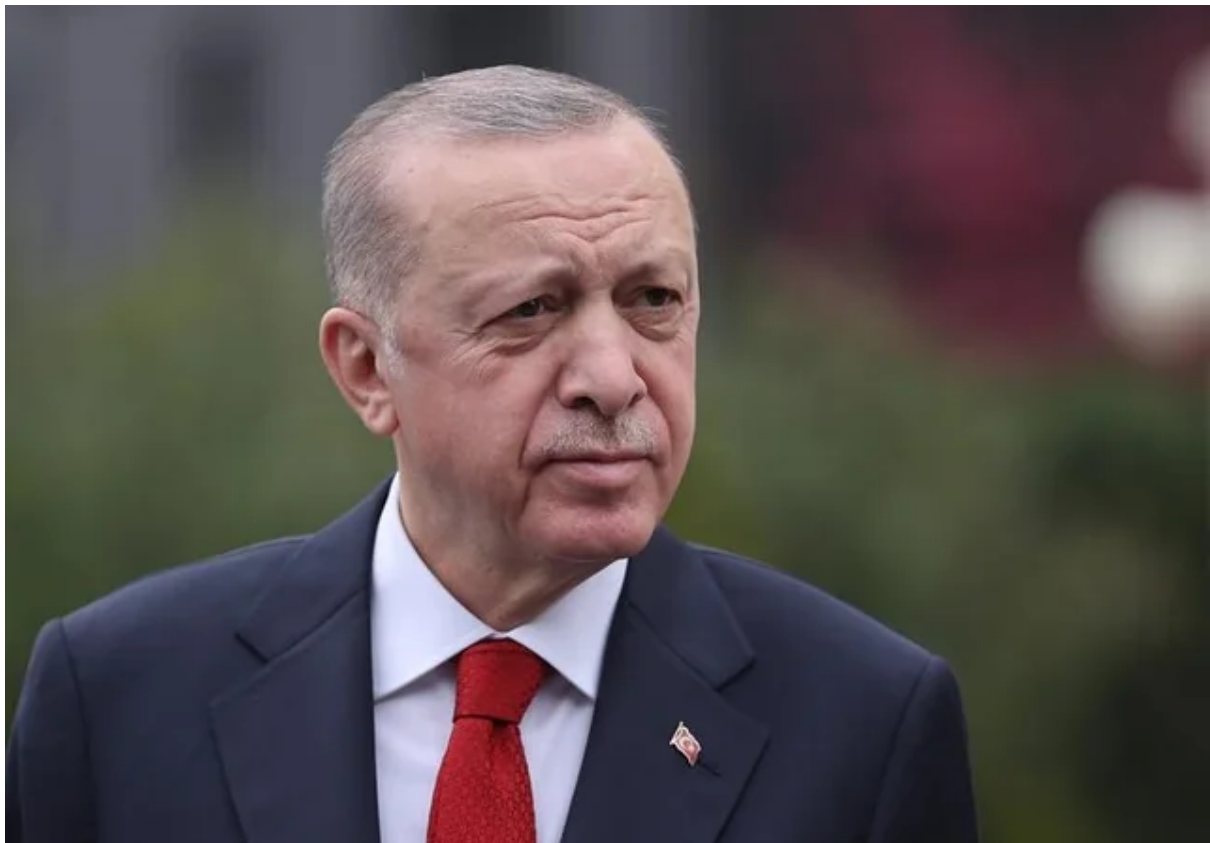
terrorist organizations depends on Jolani's behavior. "We could see HTS being removed from the list and the sanctions ending," Pedersen said.



Turkey's indispensable role

Currently, there is an interim government administration in Syria, and the process of building a normal state has begun with the active participation of foreign powers, especially Turkey. However, the Israeli factor has also come to the fore in this process. This increases the likelihood that Turkey, the main power in the region, and Israel will come face to face in Syria. Of course, we are talking about a conflict of interest. Ankara does not want Syria to be divided. The current divided state of the country is a source of danger not only for Turkey, but also for all neighboring states. The fact that Ankara, and most importantly, President Recep Tayyip Erdogan, have the main say in the process of building a new Syria is also accepted as a reality by the West. For example, the newly elected US President

Donald Trump said that Erdogan is a very smart man. He also said that Turkey has a very strong army. Experts say that Trump, who will take office after January 20, will work with Erdogan to resolve the Syrian issue. However, the current administration's views on Syria do not correspond to Turkey's interests.



Can ISIS be brought back to the stage?

Concerns have also increased about the resurgence of the ISIS threat in Syria. The remnants of ISIS, which were considered defeated for years, maintain their presence in the vast desert areas on the Syrian-Iraqi border. Experts warn that this vengeful group may try to fill the power vacuum created after the collapse of the Bashar al-Assad regime. This point has been raised more by Washington and the PKK-PYD terrorist groups it supports. The PYD threatens that "the 50,000 ISIS members it is holding in prison could be released" if they are attacked.

In such a situation, the steps Ankara will take are of interest. Turkish Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan said in an interview with Al Jazeera that what is happening in Syria today is the will of the people taking power. The presence of the PKK-YPG there is a significant threat to Turkey.

Washington threatens Ankara

Meanwhile, in the US, Democratic Senator Chris Van Hollen and Republican Senator Lindsey Graham have drawn attention for their statements in support of the YPG. Sharing their statements with Graham on the "X" platform, Van Hollen said, "Attacks by Turkish-backed forces against our Syrian Kurdish partners are a threat to regional security and efforts to prevent the resurgence of ISIS." They claimed that Turkey must accept a ceasefire and a demilitarized zone: "Otherwise, we will propose imposing sanctions on Turkey, as we did in 2019." The senators stated that they spoke with Mazlum Abdi by phone and reiterated their support for the YPG.

Thus, a new stage of great power competition has begun in Syria. Although Turkey, including many neighboring states, support a united Syria, the West and the United States, which follow the principle of "divide and rule", want to continue the tension through various terrorist groups. It is very difficult to predict in which direction the processes will progress at the present time.